

Photoshop Interface Tutorial: The Tools Palette



The "Selections Group" is where you'll find the tools that allow to select parts of your image. The icon in the top left is the Rectangular Marquee Tool. Below it is the Lasso Tool, and below that is the Crop Tool. In the top right corner, we have the Move Tool, which is not a selection tool itself but what it does do is allows you to move your selections and selected areas around the screen. Below that is the Magic Wand Tool, which allows you to select parts of your image based on similar colors and tonal values. And below the Magic Wand is the Slice Tool, used for slicing up your image for optimizing them for the web.



The next group of tools is commonly known as the "Image Editing and Painting Group". Here, you'll find tools like the Healing Brush, commonly used for removing wrinkles and skin blemishes, the Clone Stamp Tool for cloning (basically copying) one area of an image onto another area, the Eraser Tool for erasing parts of an image, and the Brush Tool for painting colors onto an image. You'll also find tools here for lightening and darkening parts of your image, and blurring and sharpening them, plus several others.



The third group of tools in the Tools palette is your "Vector Group", commonly called that because it contains tools that allow you to draw, select and move vector shapes. This is also where you'll find Photoshop's Type Tool, since type in Photoshop uses vectors rather than pixels.



In this group, you'll find the Eye Dropper, which allows you to sample colors from an image, but you'll also find the Zoom Tool which allows you to zoom in and out of the image, and the Hand Tool which allows you to drag the image around on the screen. There's also a Notes Tool.



These icons represent your foreground and background colors. The large square in the top left of this group is your current foreground color, and the similar square which appears to be behind it represents your current background color. The icon in the top right corner of this group which looks like two arrows pointing at the large squares will, if you click on it, swap your foreground and background colors. And the icon in the bottom left corner of this group, which looks like two much smaller squares, will return your foreground and background colors to their default colors.



The sixth group in the Tools palette, containing two icons which side by side which look like circles inside of squares, are used for switching back and forth between Standard editing mode and Quick Mask mode.



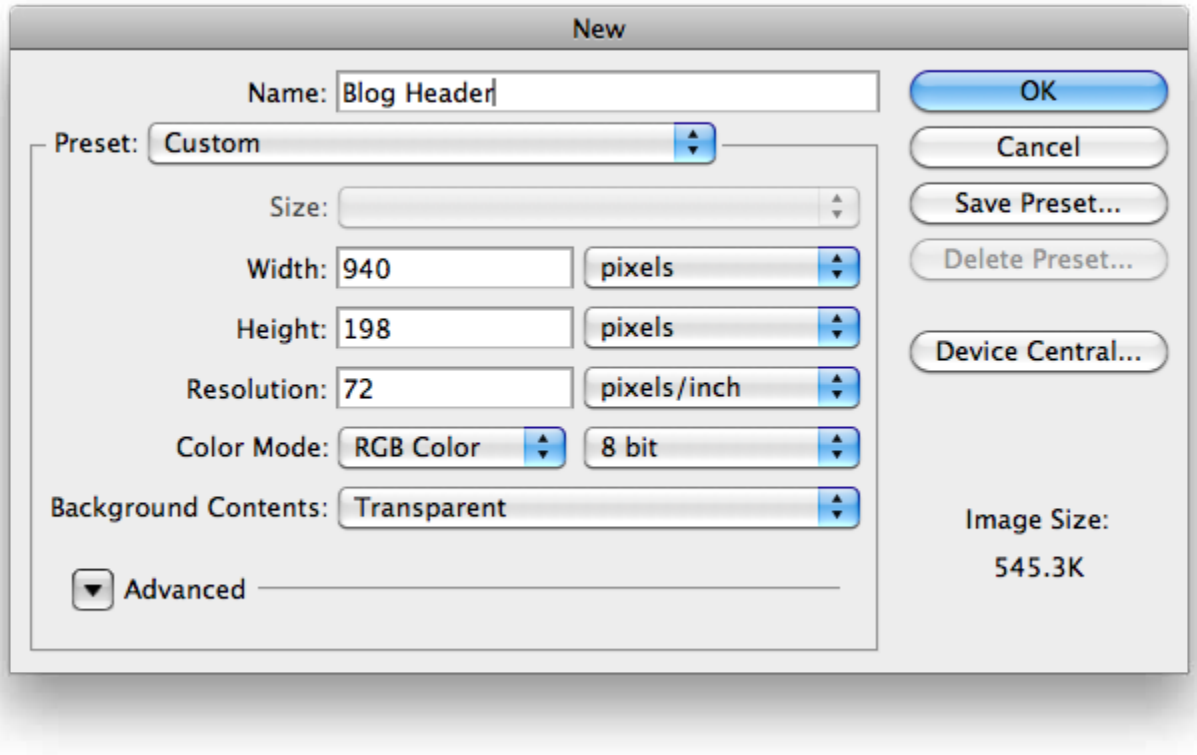
Three icons side by side that are used to switch between Photoshop's three screen modes. The first icon on the left puts Photoshop in "Standard Screen Mode". The icon in the middle selects "Full Screen Mode with Menu Bar", and the icon on the right selects "Full Screen Mode".



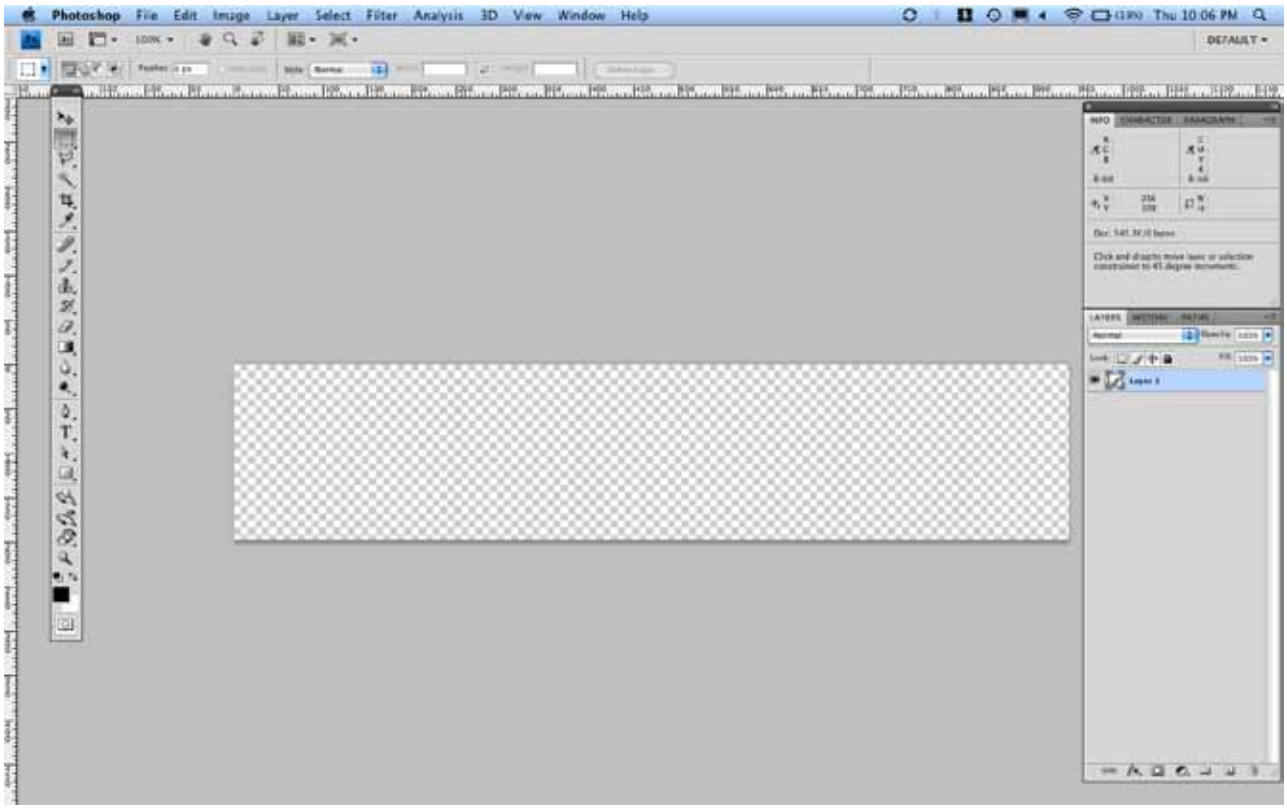
And finally, the bottom group in the Tools palette contains one icon (even though is sort of looks like two) which, if clicked, will allow us to edit our document inside ImageReady, Photoshop's web design companion.

1. Open Photoshop from the Dock/Start Menu

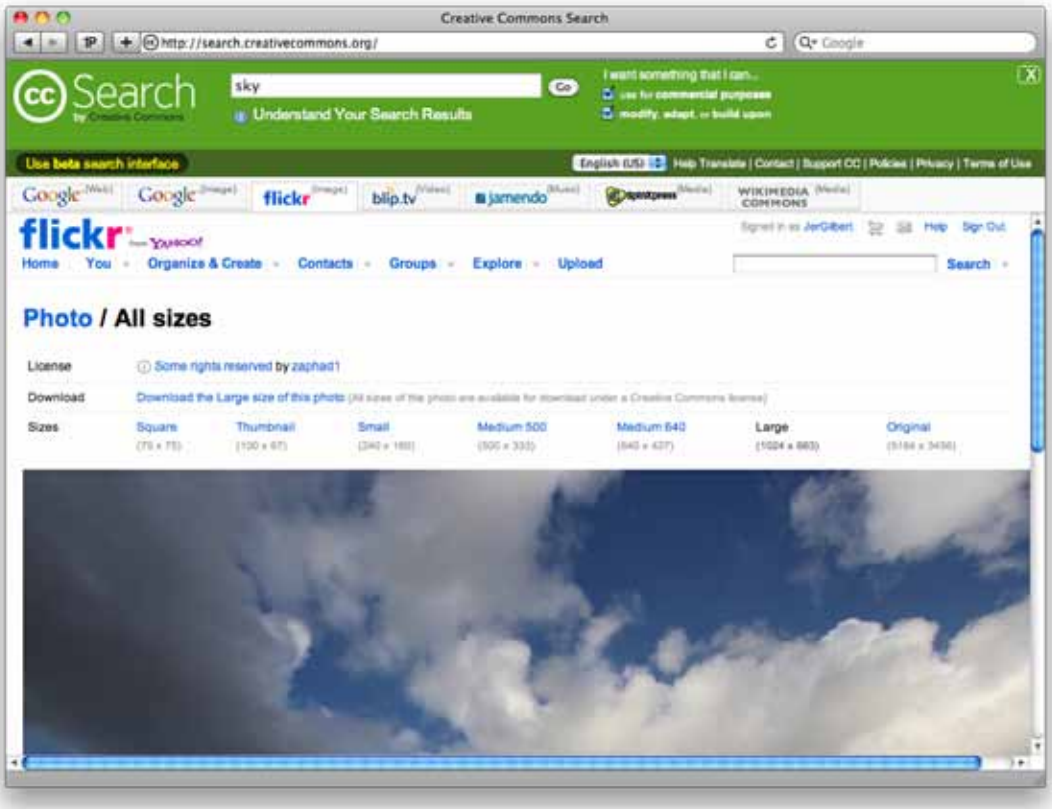
2. Create a new document File > New

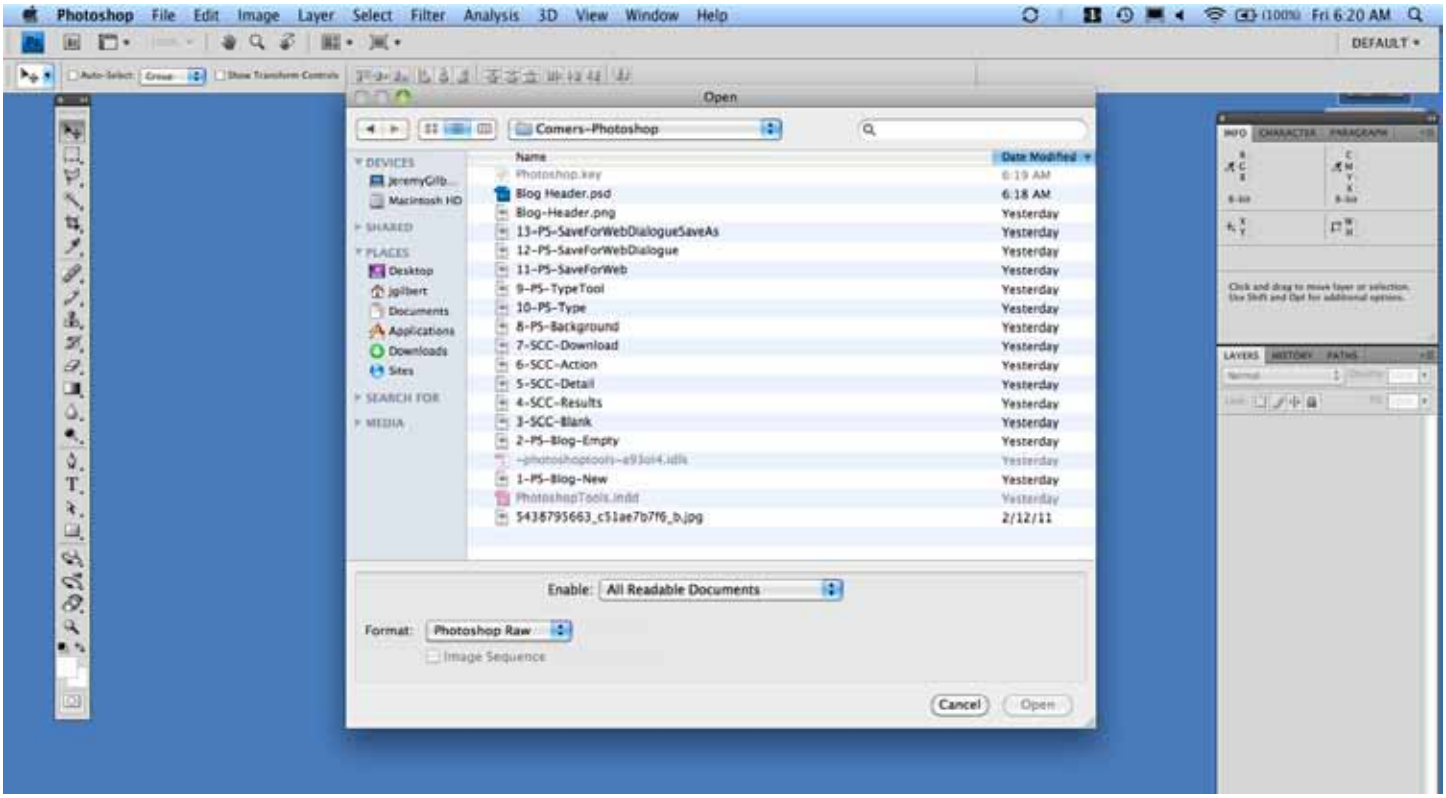


3. Document size: For our blog headers the new document should be **940 px** wide by **198 px** tall at a resolution of **72 pixels**.



4. Find an image you wish to use as a background, either by going to the internet [search.creativecommons.org is a good free resource] or using something local [on your computer]. Open that by going to File > Open.

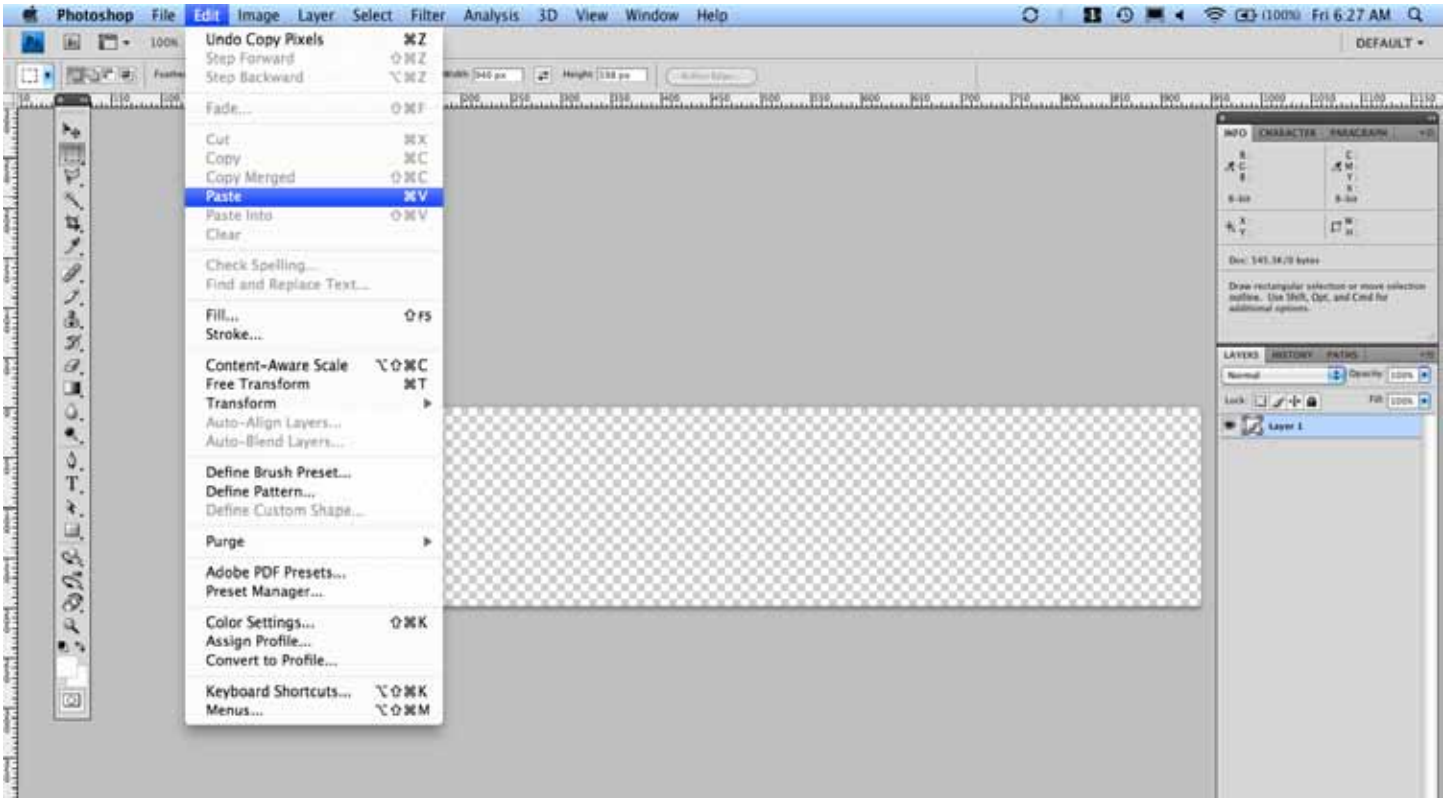




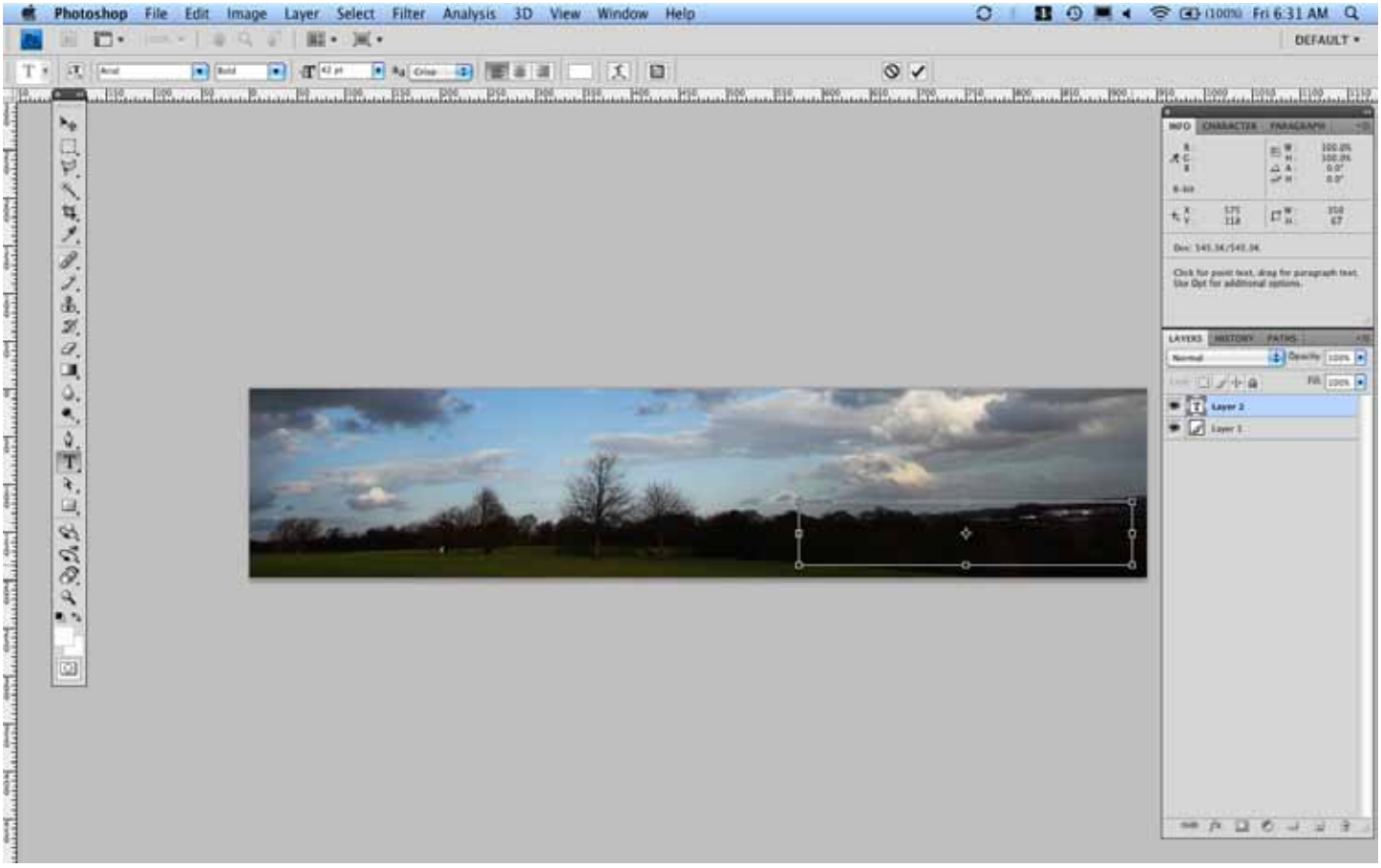
4. Use the Rectangle Marquee tool to select an area of the background image you wish to copy. Go to Edit > Copy.



5. Switch back to the empty document you created and go to Edit > Paste.



6. Using the Type Tool select and area where you wish to enter some words. When you are done select the Move Tool in your Tools palette to close the text box.



7. Save your Photoshop document by going to File > Save As. The Photoshop document (PSD) you save will be editable. Now save an image for the Web. Go to File > Save for Web. Choose a PNG-24 (PNG) and click Save.

